

Protective objects

The use of protective objects, often called amulets, dates back to the very earliest years of humanity. Whether worn, carried, or placed in the home or a holy place, amulets are believed to possess the power to ward off the evil eye, negative energy, malign spirits, or even illness. Some amulets are thought to have magical power of their own, whereas others with strong religious connotations gain their perceived power through holy blessing and the wearer's faith.

► **Mukenga masks** are worn at funerals of high-ranking members of the Kuba people of western Africa. This mask is decorated with cowrie shells, which have been used as amulets all around the world since ancient times.

Crowns give the pair regal status

The Christ child adds more holy power

Cowrie shells are linked with fertility and predicting the future



▲ **Statues of the Madonna** (mother of Christ) are thought by many Christians to have miraculous powers of protection, and believers often carry such statuettes when they travel. This one is from the Czech Republic.



▲ **Stone Venus figurines** are among the earliest portable sculptures. Made by hunter-gatherers in Europe, possibly to aid fertility, they depict women with large breasts and hips.



▲ **Crucifix pendants** are for many Christians more than a badge of their religion—they are believed to keep evil away. Crucifixes are also said to be the religious symbol most feared by vampires.



▲ **A rabbit's foot** is a found object thought to be charmed. Belief in its ability to transfer luck spans time and place—from Celtic Europe to African American Hoodoo followers in the US.